

Bespin

Named after the gas giant of the Star Wars universe, this is a real time collaboration tool aimed at coding in HTML 5

QuickTopic

Ever felt the need to start a message board for a couple of friends or colleagues to discuss something? Head over to quicktopic.com and flame away



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Wave is perhaps the most talked about web technology in recent times. The ostensibly impressive collaboration and unified communication platform was launched a while back in typical Google fashion – under a closed, perhaps permanent beta, invitation-only release. Even with the initial 1,00,000 invites, it had tons of mixed coverage and reactions. Some are calling it a confusing jumble of non-linear communication, resulting in something even less productive than email itself, while others are sitting on the fence reserving their judgement for later. Many more are embracing the beta preview and even more still are desperately waiting for their invites.

Not jumping to conclusions about the usefulness of Wave seems to be a more logical approach, because clearly Wave is an on-going work in progress. Besides, since Google has made it an open source protocol, developers can design their own interface and you never know who will leverage the API to come up with a revolutionary idea.

Coming to what Wave does, it has put instant messaging, email and wiki-like

collaboration on the same platform – with the added twist of doing things in real time. Email, the web's primary means of communication and makeshift collaboration, has been around for donkey's years. And much like the thought behind Chrome OS (Google's browser-based operating system), the guys at Google Wave too, seem to have got up one day and decided "hey email is so 90s, let's come up with something better". Google Wave aims to do just that – create an all new protocol that goes away from mailbox-to-mailbox email. In Wave, you have a hosted form of communication where metaphorically you have one email opened to which you can invite others. This should theoretically create a world without the dreaded "Reply all" button, which causes so much confusion in large email threads. Additionally, the Wave protocol is entirely open source, so developers can create their own interface and put it to better use through the API.

Even so, the idea of unified communication has been around for quite some time. In fact, there are several initiatives out there that have been doing exactly this in some form or the other. Some have been around a long time too. Many of these alternatives have been locked up in the enterprise-level commercial sphere while some are free,

Although Google Wave is the buzz lately. Believe it or not, this is not a new concept

but unheard of. Some are online following a similar hosted format to collaboration, while some like Gobby or SubEthaEdit require a client. Sure, Google Wave has managed to take enterprise-level software, juice it up, put a nice user-friendly shell around it and bring it to the ordinary consumer. But here we will look at other not-so-hyped options, and surprisingly some might even appeal to you more.

Etherpad

Unified collaboration, project management, leverage file sharing – they're all heady jargon. At the root of it all, Wave is primarily a document creation tool – much like wikis – but in real time. You thought Wave was the only to do that? You're wrong. When Wave demoed for the first time in the hour and a half long video, people gasped at the sight of being able to see what your collaborators are typing in real time. But it's not the only web app out there that can let you do that. Take Etherpad. It gives you everything – right from real time editing of documents, to rich text to a small chat window docked in the side bar. All this power-packed functionality in the simplest easy to use interface – which strangely until now, Google was renowned for. The current state in which Google Wave is functioning, with hundreds of people "collaborating" on waves which don't really have a direction or goal, gets confusing really quickly. The picture/video sharing functionality does get a thumbs up, but collaboration cannot really be centred around picture sharing – it remains just an added tool. Instead, the focused, minimalist form of document creation restricted to eight users offered by Etherpad, is better in most collaboration use case scenarios.

Etherpad offers some very interesting features. You can save any number of revisions which act as restore points. After you are done creating the write-up, there are multiple options to export the document as a Word, PDF, text and open document. There is even an undo/redo function, the lack of which is quite a pain in Google Wave, as we've mentioned in the past. Time Slider,

WHY WAVE MIGHT ACTUALLY WIPE OUT...

There are a couple of things working against Wave in terms of usability. Firstly, the ability to comment and annotate any part of the Wave is a good feature for sure, but it makes things all the more confusing. In your Inbox, you have a Wave showing 13 unread messages denoting 13 instances of people making changes to the Wave but you don't know in which part of the wave the action happened. (Yes you can use the playback option, but that too leaves a lot to be desired). This brings us to the second problem with the way things are currently going in the Wave universe. Making public Waves with hundreds and thousands of users is perfect for popularising a platform, but does it really make sense in terms of productivity? You end up with just another tool with a lot of clutter which was supposed to reduce your communications clutter in the first place. People will eventually have to come down to small focused groups. Let's not confuse collaboration with community people.